

Manager

1. Can you describe your current process for tracking & balancing teaching hours across staff?

Right now it's a shared spreadsheet. Each teacher has a row, and my co-manager and I manually add up hours as we assign lessons through the week. There's no automatic flag when someone's getting close to 40 hours, so we just eyeball it and double-check each other before Friday.

2. Can you describe the biggest pain point in your current workflow pertaining to rostering teachers?

Cross-checking teacher availability against studio availability against student requests all at once. With nine teachers and five studios, doing that by hand for every 30-minute slot is where most of my time goes, and it's also where most of our mistakes happen, such as double-booking a studio.

3. How much time do you typically spend rostering your staff?

A full day, sometimes a day and a half, every time we build the week's schedule. Most of it isn't actual decision-making, it's just checking that nothing has clashed.

4. Can you walk me through your current process when planning teacher schedules?

We start once the month's availabilities come in on the 19th. I go teacher by teacher, note who's free when, then go student by student and try to slot them into a studio and teacher that fits. New enrolments and unassigned students get handled after the recurring students are placed, since those are the trickiest to fit in.

5. How do you currently track which teachers are at capacity vs available, and what information do you need at a glance when allocating jobs?

Honestly, it's a mental tally plus the spreadsheet totals. What I actually want at a glance is: current hours assigned this week, whether they're near the 40-hour mark, what instrument they teach, and their stated preferences for the week.

6. What factors & teacher info do you consider when deciding which teacher to assign to a new student / lesson slot?

Instrument qualification first, since that's non-negotiable. Then current workload, because we're trying to keep everyone close to full but not over. Then their stated preferences, and finally continuity, since if a student's been with a teacher before we try not to switch them around.

7. When two teachers are both qualified for an instrument and both free for the same slot, what makes you pick one over the other?

Whoever's further from their requested hours gets priority, since retention matters to us, it's hard to get qualified music teachers. If it's still a tie, I look at their stated preferences for that day or time slot.

8. Walk me through how you handle late availability submissions — what's the deadline, what happens after it, and what do you weigh when deciding whether to accept a late submission?

The deadline is the 19th, and planning starts the next day. So a late submission means we're reshuffling something that's already roughly planned. I'll still accept it if the change is small or the teacher rarely misses the deadline, but if it would mean pulling a studio or slot away from someone else who's already confirmed, I push back and ask them to work with what's already been proposed.

9. What is the most important feature in the app for it to replace your daily workflow?

A landing page that shows me workload at a glance without me having to add anything up myself. If I can see who's under hours, who's over, and who's free, that alone would save most of the day I currently lose to this.

10. What is your preferred way to visualize staff workload, like charts, tables, or colour-coded indicators?

Colour-coded, definitely. A quick glance should tell me green for under capacity, amber approaching 40 hours, and red at or over. Tables are fine for the detail underneath, but the first thing I look at should be colour.

11. How do you ensure studios are utilised efficiently?

We try to fill gaps rather than spreading lessons thin across all five studios. If a studio has a hole in the afternoon, I'll look for any student who could move into it before opening up a new time slot elsewhere.

12. If a teacher is already assigned 40 hours in a week, should the system strictly block you from assigning them another lesson or should it only display a warning highlight?

Warn me, don't block me. There are legitimate reasons to go over occasionally, such as a teacher covering for someone who's sick, and I don't want the system stopping me from doing my job in that kind of situation. I just want to be clearly told I'm doing it, so it's a deliberate choice and not an accident.

13. When a teacher says that they cannot do an assigned lesson how is that currently handled?

They tell me or my co-manager directly, usually by message. We then look for another qualified teacher who's free at that time, or if it's a recurring slot, we may need to move the student instead.

14. When a teacher rejects a job after the schedule is published, what has to happen next?

I have to find a replacement fast, notify the student if the teacher changes, and update the spreadsheet everywhere that slot appears. It's the most disruptive kind of change because everything downstream has already been communicated to the student or parent.

Current Workflow & Pain Points

15. Walk me through what happens from the moment you receive a new student enquiry to when they're assigned, what steps are involved?

We take down the instrument they want and their general availability. Then I check which teachers for that instrument have open capacity in those windows, check studio availability for the same slot, confirm with the family, and then it goes into the schedule and the spreadsheet.

16. When you're planning next month's schedule, what information do you wish you had but don't?

A running average of how full each teacher's schedule usually is, so I'm not starting from zero every month. Earlier visibility into which students are likely to drop or add lessons would also help a lot.

17. How do you currently handle it when two managers need to assign teachers at the same time?

Carefully. We try to split the week so one of us owns certain teachers or days, but it's still happened that we've both tried to book the same slot. We catch it by comparing spreadsheets at the end of the day, which obviously isn't ideal.

Decision-Making & Business Rules

18. If a teacher has 38 hours this week and a new 2-hour slot opens, do you assign it or leave them under 40? What's your thinking?

I'd assign it. We're trying to maximise requested hours for retention, and 40 is a guideline for us to watch closely, not a hard ceiling, unless a labour regulation says otherwise.

19. When you have a new student who plays an instrument that only one teacher is qualified for, but that teacher is already at capacity, what do you do?

I'll ask that teacher directly if they're willing to take on the extra hours, since we know they generally want as many hours as they can get. If they say no, the student goes on a waitlist until a slot frees up.

20. Can a teacher ever be assigned to teach an instrument they aren't formally qualified for? Under what circumstances?

No, never. Qualification is a hard requirement for us, it's not something we'll compromise on regardless of scheduling pressure.

21. What happens when a teacher wants to swap assignments with another teacher? Do you allow it? How?

We allow it as long as both teachers are qualified for what they're swapping into and it doesn't create a conflict elsewhere in their schedule. It has to come through a manager though, teachers can't just arrange it between themselves and expect it to be reflected in the roster.

Edge Cases & Exceptions

22. A teacher is sick on a day they have 4 students booked. Walk me through what happens.

We first check if another qualified teacher has open slots that day. If not, we call the affected students to reschedule, usually to later in the week if there's room.

23. A student's parent calls to reschedule a lesson that's tomorrow. What's your process?

I check the teacher's availability for another slot that week and check studio availability at the same time. If nothing fits within the week, I'll push it to the following week, but that's a last resort since it throws off the monthly hour count.

24. A teacher submits availability saying they can only work mornings next month, but you know they usually work afternoons. How do you handle this?

I take it at face value and plan around it. I might follow up to ask whether it's a permanent change or just for that month, since it affects how I balance the rest of the roster, but I won't override what they've submitted.

25. What happens if a studio is double-booked by accident? How is this discovered and resolved?

Usually it's discovered when both teachers show up, or when we're doing a final check before publishing. Whoever booked it second gets moved to another studio, or specifically to the drum studio if that's the lesson type.

Reporting & Metrics

26. How do you currently measure whether a month's schedule was successful?

Mainly by how few last-minute changes we had to make, and whether teachers got close to their requested hours. Studio utilisation matters too, but it's more of a secondary check for us.

27. What reports do you produce for school management, and how often?

A monthly summary of studio utilisation and total teaching hours delivered, mostly for the profitability conversation. It's manually compiled from the spreadsheet, which takes longer than it should.

Prioritisation & Feasibility

28. If we could only build 3 features first, which would matter most to your daily work?

The workload visualisation on the landing page, the job allocation view showing up to three teachers' availability side by side, and automatic conflict detection for double-booked studios or over-capacity teachers.

29. What documents, forms, or spreadsheets do you currently use for scheduling that we should review?

The main weekly roster spreadsheet, the teacher availability submission sheet, and a separate student enrolment list. I can share all three with you.